

Aziz's Reckoning of the Bazaar Trade, as Told by the Vizier Dandan

That evening, when the stalls were shuttered and the lamps of the caravanserai were lit, Aziz sat down with a tablet of wax and reckoned the day's trade for the prince to hear, that they might know how long their disguise could feed them before their coin ran thin.

Of dibaj, two bolts had been sold, the crimson to the veiled woman for two hundred and fifty dinars, and a lesser bolt of blue to a wool merchant's wife for two hundred dinars even. Of khazz, eleven cubits had gone at forty dinars the cubit, and of atlas, one bolt only, at ninety dinars, for the buyers of atlas are few and proud and slow to part with silver.

Of the spices, the saffron had sold entire, all four measures at thirty dinars each, for a cook from the palace kitchens had come seeking it for a feast and would not be refused. The pepper and the musk sold more slowly, and the frankincense not at all, for the temple that once bought it had lately taken a supplier of its own.

Aziz set the sum of the day's trade at one thousand one hundred and sixty dinars, and told the prince plainly that at such a rate they might keep their stall through the season, though not forever.

He told the prince also of a thing he had heard from a porter idling near the stall: that an old gardener tended the grounds behind the White Palace, a man fond of wine and coin alike, and known to speak freely to strangers who paid for his cups. Whoever wished to come near the princess unseen, the porter said, would do well to seek out this gardener first, and not the palace guard.

The prince resolved that they should seek the gardener out upon the morrow, and put away the tablet, and slept with the portrait of the princess Dunya folded still against his heart.